Closer, Not Busier

A Before/After Count of Play at the Courtyard Chess Tables Facilities Moved Nearer the Main Walkway

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Abstract. Facilities' Horizon Register nominates low-cost amenity relocations on the assumption that a more visible site draws more use, extending logic the Trajectory Analytics Group elsewhere applies to institutional priorities to the physical furniture Facilities schedules. Here, the University's two outdoor chess tables were relocated 34 metres from a shaded courtyard corner to a spot fronting the courtyard's busiest walkway, a pilot for a wider sightline-led siting doctrine the Register plans to extend. We tracked sit-down play at the relocated tables and an unmoved control site for nine weeks before the move and nine after, coding time-lapse imagery for play sessions, session duration, and daily walkway pedestrian counts as a direct measure of the visibility the Register's logic invokes. Weekly sessions were statistically indistinguishable before and after the move (mean 5.8 versus 6.2; n.s.), tracking the control site's own flat weekly mean of 5.1 throughout. Session duration held at a 28-minute median across the pre-move, early post-move, and late post-move periods, and daily pedestrian counts, which rose roughly fivefold after the move, showed no relationship with same-day sessions in either period. We find no evidence that visibility alone drove the uptake the Register's logic anticipated, and discuss what the result may mean for the doctrine's wider rollout.

Introduction

The University's two outdoor chess tables have sat in a shaded corner of the Learning Commons courtyard since they were installed, visible chiefly to whoever was already seated there. In the most recent capital-works round, Facilities' Horizon Register listed the tables among a small batch of low-cost amenity relocations, moving both 34 metres to the courtyard's northern edge, fronting the walkway that carries the heaviest foot traffic between the Learning Commons and the refectory. The Register's stated rationale was straightforward: a more visible site should draw more use, on the same anticipatory logic the Trajectory Analytics Group applies elsewhere to institutional priorities, extended here to furniture. No usage baseline accompanied the decision, and no review date has yet been set to test whether the anticipated uptake materialised.

The assumption is not unreasonable on its face: something more people walk past should, all else equal, draw more of the people who walk past it. What the assumption elides is that walking past a chess table and sitting down to play are different acts, separated by the time, a partner, and the inclination the walkway itself does nothing to supply. Visibility can inform a passerby that a table exists without doing anything to make anyone want to sit at it.

We test whether the relocation changed how often anyone sat down to play, tracking usage at the tables and at an unmoved control site both before and after the move.

We make three contributions, each hedged to what eighteen weeks at one courtyard can show. First, we assemble a matched before/after dataset of coded play sessions at the relocated tables and an unmoved control site, isolating any change attributable to the move itself from a term's ordinary drift in outdoor activity. Second, we test the Register's visibility mechanism directly, setting daily walkway pedestrian counts against same-day play sessions rather than assuming the relationship the siting decision took for granted. Third, we test whether any effect was simply slow to appear, comparing the weeks immediately after the move against the weeks further out, and discuss what a relocation that changed a site's visibility without changing its use may mean for the wider doctrine the Register plans to extend it into.

Related work

Visibility is a standing assumption in public-space design: an amenity that cannot be seen from where people already move is read as unlikely to draw anyone toward it, a logic with a long lineage running through the crime-prevention design literature's treatment of natural surveillance [1], and more recently quantified directly as a measurable property of a site's openings and sightlines rather than an impression [2]. Campus-specific work finds the same pattern: students report favouring outdoor social and study spaces with maximum visibility, alongside seating and shade, in observational audits of university plazas [3].

Whether visibility alone converts into use is a separate, more contested question. Natural experiments installing or relocating outdoor recreation amenities return a mixed record: playground and park renewal both show visitation gains statistically indistinguishable from a matched control in some settings [4], [5], sidewalk improvements shift self-reported but not accelerometer-measured activity [6], and outdoor fitness-equipment installations produce visitation increases that are frequently non-significant against a control park [7], [8], even as usage rates for installed equipment remain low overall [9], [10], save where a diverse, age-targeted facility mix shows clearer gains [11]. Elsewhere the same amenity class shows a clearer positive result: improved bus stops draw a significantly larger ridership gain than unimproved control stops [12], and an outdoor table-tennis pilot reported high, self-organised uptake with few participation barriers [13]. The closest institutional parallel is a shuttle-stop relocation that produced an apparent ridership rise entirely attributable to reallocated existing traffic rather than new demand [14]. Facilities' siting logic sits closer to a planning-fallacy pattern documented well beyond public-space design, where forecasters systematically anticipate more favourable outcomes than a comparable reference class supports [15], [16]. Before-after-control-impact designs of the kind we use here were developed precisely to separate a genuine site-specific effect from a broader trend a single before/after comparison would otherwise absorb [17].

Method

The study site is the University's Learning Commons courtyard, home to the campus's only outdoor chess tables: two fixed concrete tables with inlaid boards, previously sited in a shaded corner against the courtyard's southern wall. In week 10 of an 18-week study term, Facilities relocated both tables 34 metres to the courtyard's northern edge, immediately fronting the paved walkway that field counts confirm carries the highest midday foot traffic of any route between the Learning Commons and the refectory, filed as a Horizon Register item citing the new site's visibility as the basis for an anticipated rise in use. We treat the relocation as a natural experiment and adopt a before-after-control-impact design [17], comparing the relocated tables against an unmoved control site — the Arts Courtyard's two outdoor draughts tables, roughly 400 metres away and unaffected by any Facilities works during the study term — across nine weeks before the move and nine weeks after.

A time-lapse camera at each site captured one frame every two minutes from 7am to 9pm across all eighteen weeks, the same monitoring approach used elsewhere for continuous outdoor-recreation observation in place of continuous human presence [18]. Two coders, blind to the study period and to each other's codes, reviewed each site's frame sequence and logged every distinct *play session* — two or more people seated with pieces in active play for at least three consecutive minutes — separately from a passer-by pause, a single person resetting pieces, or a seated but non-playing occupancy. Coding disagreements (6.1% of sessions) were resolved by a third independent review. Each logged session's duration was recorded in minutes. The same frames were used to derive a daily walkway pedestrian count at each site: a systematic two-minute count taken once per daylight hour, summed across the day, as a direct measure of the visibility the Register's siting logic invokes.

We compare weekly session counts at the relocated tables against the control site before and after the move, test session duration across the pre-move, early post-move (weeks 10-13), and late post-move (weeks 14-18) periods to check for a delayed uptake the headline comparison might miss, and regress daily session counts against same-day pedestrian counts within each period to test the visibility mechanism directly rather than assuming it.

Results

Weekly sessions at the relocated tables rose nominally from a pre-move mean of 5.8 to a post-move mean of 6.2 ($n = 9$ weeks each side; n.s., two-sample t-test), a gap smaller than the control site's own week-to-week standard deviation and unaccompanied by any shift in the control site's own flat weekly mean, which holds at 5.1 sessions across both halves of the same eighteen weeks (Figure 1).

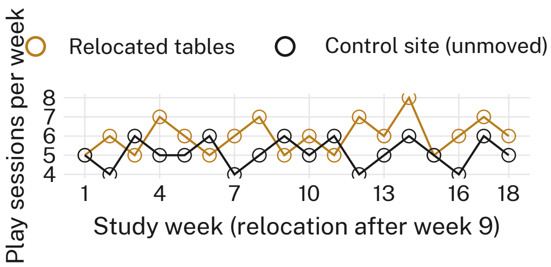

Figure 1: Weekly play sessions at the relocated tables against the unmoved control site: both track each other before and after the week-10 move, with no divergence coinciding with the relocation.

Session duration shows the same pattern. Median play-session length holds at 28 minutes in the pre-move period, the early post-move period, and the late post-move period alike (Figure 2), which rules out both a shift toward shorter, more casual sittings at the more exposed site and a delayed uptake that the headline nine-versus-nine comparison, ending only five weeks after the move, might otherwise have missed.

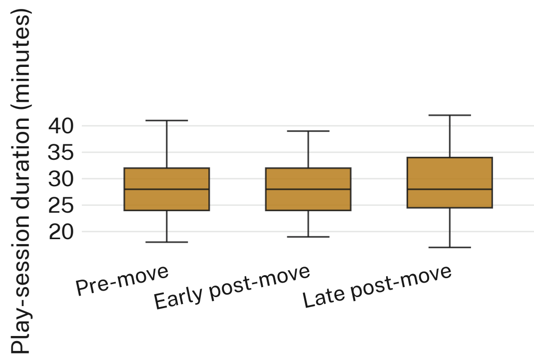

Figure 2: Play-session duration by period: the median holds at 28 minutes pre-move, early post-move, and late post-move alike — an ablation that changes nothing.

The relocation did change what the Register's siting logic depends on: daily walkway pedestrian counts at the table site rose from a pre-move range of roughly 90-180 to a post-move range of roughly 430-880, close to a fivefold increase in the visibility the tables are exposed to. Same-day session counts did not follow. Regressing sessions on pedestrian counts returns a flat fitted line in both the pre-move period ($r = 0.04$) and the post-move period ($r = -0.06$), and the two period's session counts occupy the same narrow 0-2 range despite occupying almost entirely non-overlapping pedestrian-count ranges (Figure 3). The precondition the Register's logic requires — more people walking past — was met in full; the uptake the precondition was meant to anticipate was not.

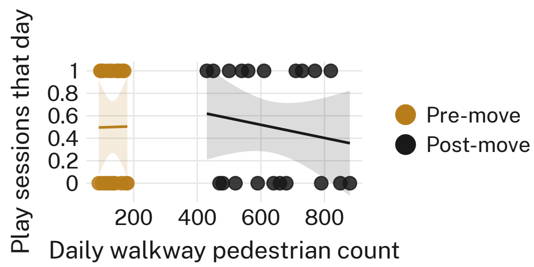

Figure 3: Daily pedestrian counts against same-day play sessions, pre- and post-move: the move raises pedestrian exposure roughly fivefold while sessions stay flat, and neither period's fitted line distinguishes itself from zero slope.

Discussion

These results suggest that visibility, on the evidence of this relocation, was not the binding constraint on chess-table use that the Horizon Register item assumed it to be. The precondition for the Register's anticipated trajectory was satisfied cleanly: pedestrian exposure at the table site rose by a wide and unambiguous margin. What did not follow was the use that exposure was meant to catalyse, at any point across nine post-move weeks and across every measure we tracked — weekly counts, session duration, and the direct pedestrian-to-session relationship alike. Prior work at this institution has found a Trajectory Analytics Group horizon-scan recommendation's renewal rate holds steady even after the signal that justified it lapses [19]; our result raises a related question one step earlier, before a renewal decision is due, about what happens to a capital-works item whose anticipated trajectory simply fails to arrive on schedule. We do not read this result as evidence that visibility is irrelevant to outdoor-amenity use in general, a claim well beyond what one relocation can support; the narrower and, we think, more useful reading is that visibility appears to have been necessary but nowhere near sufficient at this site, and that the Register's siting doctrine, as currently specified, has no mechanism for distinguishing the two. A pedestrian count is an easy proxy for a Register that needs a checkable figure at decision time, and a measure adopted because it is available rather than because it is accurate is a recognised failure mode in institutional metrics generally [20]; our result is one more instance of that caution, recorded before rather than after the doctrine's wider rollout.

Limitations

Our evaluation covers a single relocation, a single control site, and one 18-week term, though the null holds identically across three independent measures — weekly counts, session duration, and the pedestrian regression — and across both the early and late post-move subperiods, which we take as evidence against a one-off seasonal or settling-in artefact rather than a single fragile result. Two-minute frame sampling may miss the shortest passer-by interactions, but this affects both sites and both periods equally and would not manufacture the specific pattern we observe. Our pedestrian counts measure exposure at the table site rather than intention to stop, so we cannot rule out that some passers-by registered the tables without forming any view of whether to play, a distinction future work with intercept surveys could resolve.

Conclusion

We set nine weeks of play at the University's relocated outdoor chess tables against nine weeks before the move and against an unmoved control site, finding no detectable change in weekly session counts or session duration despite a roughly fivefold rise in the pedestrian traffic the relocation was meant to convert into use. The Horizon Register's visibility-drives-uptake assumption held for the precondition it could control directly and did not hold for the outcome it was filed to produce. We suggest the Register treat visibility as one input among several before it extends the same siting doctrine to its next batch of amenities, rather than as a sufficient basis on its own. Future work should test whether visibility paired with a lower-effort prompt — a seating change, a stored set of pieces — closes the gap this relocation alone did not.

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